



IN TUNE WITH TRADITIONS
(Far left) Women playing kabaddi during Chhattisgarhia Olympics at Nagari block in Dhamtari district; CM Bhupesh Baghel tries his hand at spinning a top after inaugurating the event in Raipur, Oct. 6

the proceedings keenly, raid the turf to embrace their mothers.

It's Olympics time in Chhattisgarh. Kabaddi, *gilli danda* (tip-cat), *pitthul* (seven stones), *banti* (marbles), *langdi daud* (one-legged race), *rassakashi* (tug of war) and *bhanwara* (spinning top), sports that were an intrinsic part of Indian tradition till video games and smartphones invaded the landscape and children's minds, are part of the first-of-its-kind extravaganza that kicked off on October 6 and has come to be called Chhattisgarhia Olympics. Young or old, man or woman, villager or townsperson, all Chhattisgarhis are welcome to take part in 14 disciplines during the multi-sport event that also includes the internationally recognised long jump and 100-metre dash (see *The Folk Games*).

"The initiative will promote traditional sports, which we shouldn't let vanish," Chief Minister Bhupesh Baghel said while inaugurating the event at the Balbir Singh Juneja Indoor Stadium in state capital Raipur. Not just entertainment, the event will also encourage participants to keep fit, he added. A massive advertising campaign is driving home the message, with jingles in Chhattisgarhi dialect playing in cinema halls too. Even the Twitter account of the chief minister's office (CMO) recently posted a video of a 75-year-old woman taking part in the *bhanwara* event at a village in Baloda Bazar district, in which she is being feted for her skill and enthusiasm.

GAME PLAN

The Baghel-led Congress government's pitch to conserve and promote local traditions and culture, including sports, is apparently aimed as a political masterstroke to usurp the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)'s nationalist and revivalist agenda. "Chhattisgarh has a rich cultural tradition, which was not allowed to flourish in the past," claims sports minister Umesh Patel. "The CM has been making attempts to popularise Chhattisgarhi food, language and local knowhow in agriculture and other professions. The Chhattisgarhia Olympics are also a step in that direction." A few months ago, it was the state's traditional cuisine that took centre stage at an agriculture festival, pitched as a panacea for summer-related illnesses. Political observers feel a strong 'Chhattisgarhi identity' can consolidate public support in favour of those promoting it.

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Though the games are being played in both villages and towns, the focus is predominantly rural, as the Baghel government aspires in most of the other schemes launched in its nearly four-year tenure. Farm loan waiver, paddy procurement at prices above the MSP, doles for rural landless labourers and the much-hyped '*gobar* economy', wherein the government has been buying cow dung from cattle owners to prepare compost—all are centred around the rural population. It comes as no surprise, as over three-quarters of the state's population lives in villages. Tribal communities alone account for 30 per cent of the population, the highest among all states barring the Northeast.

As the Congress prepares for the assembly election due next year, the three-month-long event also gives it an opportunity to engage its second- and third-tier leaders, who often complain